



DESERT CANYONS

MOUNTAIN PEAKS

OCEAN COAST

WIDE OPEN SPACES

KIND HEARTS ♥

Mav





STORY TEXT

It was a Saturday morning, and Dad had that look on his face — the one that meant something big was coming. He stood in the living room holding a rolled-up map the size of a small tablecloth and grinned so wide his ears nearly touched. “Family meeting!” he announced. “We’re going on a ROAD TRIP.” Mav, the big bullmastiff, immediately sat up straight and knocked his water bowl off the coffee table. Moony, the dachshund, slowly



STORY TEXT

Packing was an event. Dad tried to fit three suitcases, a cooler, two sleeping bags, a guitar, a boogie board, and a bag of dog food into the back of a minivan that was already full of optimism. Mav helpfully carried things to the car — mostly things that were not supposed to go to the car, like a throw pillow and the TV remote. Moony sat in the driveway and watched the chaos with the calm dignity of a small dog who knew exactly what was



STORY TEXT

They pulled out of the driveway at 7 a.m. sharp, which actually meant 8:15 a.m. because Theo forgot his water bottle and then Dad forgot his sunglasses and then Moony had to make an emergency trip back inside that nobody asked questions about. But finally — FINALLY — the minivan rolled down the street and the adventure began. The open road stretched ahead of them, wide and long and golden in the morning sun. Mav had his head out the window, ears flapping like two flags. This was living.



STORY TEXT

Texas was big. Really, really big. They drove for hours and it was still Texas. Mile after mile of wide blue sky, mesquite trees, and roadside signs advertising things like 'WORLD'S LARGEST BELT BUCKLE — 14 MILES.' They stopped at a roadside BBQ stand called Big Earl's — a weathered red barn with smoke curling up into the afternoon sky — and the



STORY TEXT

Behind Big Earl's BBQ, in a wide pasture that went on forever, stood the most impressive animal any of them had ever seen. He was a Texas Longhorn, dusty brown with horns that stretched wider than Dad's arms could reach. His name, a wooden sign



★ **STORY TEXT** ★

★ **DIALOGUE** ★



STORY TEXT

They prayed — right there on the side of the highway. Dad's hand on Mom's, kids

DIALOGUE



Rosa: (already pulling out her jack) 'Flat tire? I got you. Been there about a hundred times on this road.'



STORY TEXT

Crossing into New Mexico felt like driving onto another planet. The landscape shifted from flat green

DIALOGUE

Lily: "It looks like Mars."

Dad: "Kind of does, doesn't it?"

Theo: "Are there Martians in New Mexico?"



STORY TEXT

They stopped at a rest area in New Mexico when a streak of brown and white shot across

DIALOGUE

Dusty: (talking extremely fast) “HeyHowyadoingNicevanWhereyou headedGrandCanyonCoolIbeenthereoncetwicemaybeFivetimes



STORY TEXT

Dusty's shortcut turned out to be less of a shortcut and more of a scenic tour of

DIALOGUE

Theo: "Are we there yet?"

Moony: "Twelve."

Theo: "What?"



★ STORY TEXT ★

Dad turned off the engine. The desert went quiet—a big, wide, surprisingly peaceful quiet.

★ DIALOGUE ★

Dad: “Let’s pray.”

Theo: “Praying means we’re lost.”



STORY TEXT

Nothing prepares you for the Grand Canyon. You

DIALOGUE

(Forty-five seconds of complete silence.)

Then “Whoo!”



STORY TEXT

The next morning they hiked the rim trail, which was gorgeous and also terrifying

DIALOGUE

Mav: (noticing) 'MOONY —'

Moony: (one paw over the edge, peering down) 'I just



STORY TEXT

The shadow came first — enormous, sliding

DIALOGUE

Theo: (hiding behind Dad) ‘Is it going to eat us?’



STORY TEXT

Canyon had been born with feathers

DIALOGUE

Canyon: "I used to hide. Thought being different

not a few stars, not a scattering of stars, but a whole universe of them, wall to wall across the sky, so thick and bright that Theo sat down hard in the grass because his legs stopped working from the beauty of it. Mav lay on his back in the dirt, paws in the air, staring straight up, as happy as a dog can be.

★ DIALOGUE ★

Theo: (sitting in the grass, neck craned up) 'There are so many.'

Mom: 'David wrote about this. "The heavens declare the glory of God.'"

Lily: 'Psalm 19.'

Mom: 'That's right.'

Dad: (arm around Mom) 'He made every one of those. Named them all.'

Mav: (still on his back in the dirt)



worked hierarchically. Everyone had been in the car for four hours. Moony had reorganized the snack bag twice out of boredom. Theo had invented a game called 'Count the Identical Shrubs' and was currently at 847. The general mood could be described as 'alive, but only technically.'

DIALOGUE

Theo: 'Eight hundred and forty-eight. Eight hundred and forty-nine.'

Lily: 'Theo please stop.'

Theo: 'Eight hundred and fifty.'

Dad: 'How about a road trip game?'



Mav: (approaching slowly) “Hey. You okay?”

Neon: (startled, trying to look casual) “What? Yeah. Totally. Just hanging out. In this parking lot. By myself. In the desert.”

Moony: “You’re lost.”

Neon: “I’m not LOST, I’m just... directionally uncertain.”

Moony: “That’s lost.”

Neon: (ears drooping slightly) “...Yeah. A little bit lost.”

Mav: (sitting down beside him) “Where are you trying to go?”

Neon: “I’m trying to find the rest of my family. We got separated two days ago and I don’t know which way they went.”

Mav: “Then we’ll help you find them.”





DIALOGUE



PAGE 20 — LIGHTS OF LAS VEGAS

They weren't stopping in Las Vegas — just passing through — but the highway went right past the Strip, and at dusk the lights came on all at once and it was something. Enormous hotels. Cascading LED signs. Colors in every direction. The kind of overwhelming, can't-look-away spectacle that feels exciting for about five minutes and then just feels very loud. Mav looked at it thoughtfully. Moony looked at it and then immediately looked away and stared at the floor.

Theo: (face pressed to window) “WOW. Can we stop? Can we PLEASE stop?”



STORY TEXT

The mountains appeared gradually — first as shapes on the horizon, then as real walls of stone rising up to meet the highway.

DIALOGUE

Lily: *(reading the road sign)* “Welcome to California!”

Theo: “Does California have bears?”

Mom: “Theo —”



PAGE 22 – THE PACIFIC OCEAN

STORY TEXT

Nobody was ready. Not really. You can know the ocean is big and still not be ready for the moment you come over a hill on the Pacific Coast Highway and there it is: infinite blue, horizon to horizon, the sun making a road of light straight across the water toward you. Dad pulled into a beach parking lot and nobody even waited for him to fully stop. Doors flew open. Shoes came off before feet hit the pavement. Theo ran so hard toward the



Moony was having a perfectly dignified time observing the ocean from the dry sand when a rogue wave — bigger than the others, sneaky, apparently personally offended by dachshunds — came rolling in faster than expected. Moony turned to run. The wave was faster. The wave won. When it receded, Moony was sitting in an inch of water looking like a very small, very soggy, very undignified dog. He turned slowly to look at Mav.

DIALOGUE

Mav (sitting on the sand, looking at Moony) "You're a dachshund, aren't you?"

now dry but still dignified, regarded her with careful respect.

Theo: "What if the ocean is the problem? I just got knocked over by it."

Paloma: (looking at Theo) "...That's different. That's just waves being waves."



was the most natural thing in the world.
Like the Psalm was written with
beach afternoons in mind.



Mav: “Be still and know.”



Paloma: “Be STILL. Most people
skip that part.”



Moony: “...I’ve been fighting
rest this whole trip.”



Paloma: “Most do. Until they
stop fighting.”



*Moony lets out a long sigh and
closes his eyes in the warm
afternoon sun.*



Mav: “There he is.”

interest — and then sat around the fire talking about the trip. Every state. Every moment. Every animal they'd met. Each one had given them something. A word. A lesson. A new way of seeing.

DIALOGUE

Lily: “Brisket said the best things are rarely reassuring.”

Theo: “Dusty was the most chaotic creature I've ever encountered and I respect him for it.”

Mom: “Canyon taught me that being different can be the very thing that makes you soar.”

Dad: “Neon reminded me that a little help at the right moment changes everything.”



down in a small notebook. Mav noticed. He didn't say anything.
He just smiled.



Mav: (to Moony, half-asleep beside him)
"Do you know what's been in every single state we drove through?"

Moony: (one eye open) "Bad GPS signal?"

Mav: "God."

Moony: "...Yeah."

Mav: "Different places. Different faces. Different landscapes. But the same love everywhere. Waiting in every rest stop and every overlook and every parking lot with a lost jackrabbit."

Moony: "He's hard to miss once you start looking."

Mav: "That's exactly it. You just have to start looking."



Mav: "We're home."

Moony: "...I missed this pillow. Genuinely. I missed this pillow."

Mav: "I know you did."

Moony: "I'm not saying the trip wasn't worth it. It was. Every mile."

Mav: "But?"

Moony: "But this pillow didn't come up once. Not once. And I think that's God's design too."

Mav: *(laughing)* "He made you a homebody, Moony."

Moony: "He made me a homebody who goes on adventures. There's a difference."



Moony: (reading it one more time, quietly)
'Every person matters to God. Even dogs.'
(A long pause.)
Moony: '...I really like that kid.'
Mav: 'I know you do.'
Moony: 'When's the next road trip?'
Mav: (grinning) 'I thought you'd never ask.'



FAITH TAILS

youtube.com/@FaithTails

Mav & Moony The Great American Road Trip

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"For God so loved the world..."

John 3:16